Syria. By the end of 2017, Iranian and Russian assisted forces were rapidly asserting control over Syrian territory. In short, Russia's military intervention in Syria eased the spectre of Sino–Iranian entente, which loomed large when the JCPOA took full effect in January 2016.

The election as president of Donald Trump in November 2016 was a second factor resetting the Iranian chessboard. Trump had campaigned by damning the JCPOA (along with the North American Free Trade Agreement, the Paris climate accord, and the Transpacific Partnership) as an unfair and unbalanced deal engineered by naïve and inept US negotiators. Trump promised to withdraw from all if elected and in May 2018 gave notice of US withdrawal from the JCPOA. That agreement had come into full effect only in January 2016, when Iran's compliance with key measures was verified. Severe US-imposed sanctions against Iran came into effect in November 2018. This meant that the JCPOA and the opening for China–Indian competition for Iran's favour lasted only about three years.

Both China and India responded to the lifting of sanctions via the JCPOA by increasing the purchase of Iranian oil, becoming by 2017 respectively the first and second ranking customers for Iranian oil.[23] India expanded economic and security cooperation with Iran, especially regarding development of the now-revived Chabahar project. India was especially vulnerable to US pressure to wind down purchases of Iranian oil because New Delhi had been pushing for closer strategic-military cooperation with the United States. In meetings with Secretary of State Mike Pompeo and Secretary of Defense James Mattis in late 2018, the American envoys argued that protection of India's evolving partnership with the United States required Indian cooperation in isolating Iran, especially because this had been the case during the pre-JCPOA era.

Indian leaders advanced a number of arguments countering US pressure. India had complied with US wishes